HOW TO STAY SAFE AFTER COVID

Vital recovery tips from Dr T. Chandrasekhar, Director of Internal Medicine at Fortis Hiranandani Hospital, Mumbai



REST
Ease yourself back into routine life. It is important to give your body time to recover fully from the illness



EAT RIGHT
Light and fresh food gives the body the essential nutrients it needs to heal itself



REDUCE MENTAL STRESS
Cognitive or psychological issues can hamper recovery; they can also be a sign of other underlying post-Covid problems



GO FOR REGULAR CHECK-UPS
In case of any symptom, consult a doctor immediately; get routine check-ups post recovery



GET VACCINATED
Fully vaccinated people stand less chances of getting severe Covid; it also reduces risks of post-Covid complications



THE RIGHT MEDICATION
Do not self-medicate; pills (including supplements) should be taken after consulting a doctor

while you can test negative for Covid, you have to keep on monitoring your overall health. Caution is the best treatment," says Dr Chakravarty.

HOW TO TREAT LONG COVID

In the absence of a time-frame for Long Covid symptoms, doctors are increasingly recommending routine check-ups and exercising caution after recovery. "One cannot be callous about Covid," says Dr Chandrasekhar. "What is going on internally, only a medical practitioner can diagnose. Visible symptoms should be immediately reported to the relevant doctor. If there are no symptoms, one should still undergo routine health check-ups in the months following recovery," he adds. Post-Covid care includes rest, a light and nutritious diet, light to moderate exercise and regular doctor consultations for at least the first one month. Vaccination too plays a key role in reducing the risk of Long Covid. According to a survey by the Office for National Statistics (ONS) published in January 2022, those who had taken both doses of Pfizer, Moderna or AstraZeneca vaccines were half as likely to develop Long Covid versus those who have received one dose or none.

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In some cases, Long Covid cannot be prevented, only treated. After a severe bout of illness during India's Delta wave in May 2021, Megha Juyal never regained her physical strength. Her reduced physical functioning is still so severe that even a year after recovery, she can't walk and talk at the same time. "I used to make office calls while walking every evening. Now that makes me breathless," says the 46-year-old Delhi-based homemaker.

Experts say that after severe Covid, which involves hospitalisation, Long Covid is almost a certainty. The only answer is to support such patients through long-term physical rehab, diet control, and monitoring. Several major hospitals such as Apollo, Fortis and Medanta now have separate Long Covid care centres where medical programmes are tailored to treat long-term symptoms. For those who have had long Covid for more than six months, doctors also advise taking psychological support to handle the trauma of continued ill health. "It is frightening to not be able to function physically the way one used to and this can lead to mental stress," says Dr Tilwe. Such stress can be managed through counselling and, in extreme cases, medication.

Over the past two years, over 43 million Indians have had Covid infection. Yet, there are still many unanswered questions about Long Covid—how can it be diagnosed, who is likely to get it, and how long will it last? Experts point to a growing need for more research and to better understand and treat the full gamut of post-Covid complications. While Covid itself might weaken into no more than a seasonal flu eventually, 'long' Covid might last for much longer. ■